

DESIGN AUDIT / WORKING DOCUMENT

The Carter Law Firm, P.C.

A design and accessibility review of carterlawwins.com

PREPARED FOR
SCOPE

Marketing & Design partner

Homepage, hero, practice areas, header, navigation, lead-capture form, Spanish landing page, and shared CSS / tokens.

STACK
AUDIENCE OF THE SITE

Next.js 16 (App Router) · React 19 · Tailwind v4 · Framer Motion · TypeScript

Recent truck-accident victims, in pain, on a phone, often bilingual. Primary action: book the free case evaluator. Secondary: Spanish-speaker capture.

BRAND POSITION

Fierce. Boxer / warrior. Winner. Bilingual. Confidence expressed through restraint, not billboard volume.

Headline

The bones are strong. The decoration is templated.

The site has a serious type pairing, a real palette, and meaningful performance work already done. The strategic foundation is sound. But four recurring design decisions pull the site back toward the billboard-firm register the brand explicitly rejects: a metallic gold gradient on every primary button, an italic-bronze emphasis used on every section heading, two animated gradient-text classes in the global stylesheet, and a flat eight-tile grid that treats truck accidents as one of eight equal practices rather than the firm's positioning.

Underneath those is one structural concern worth flagging early: the primary conversion target on the homepage is an unowned third-party iframe. That makes the most important element on the site the one we have least control over — for accessibility, for tracking, and for Spanish parity.

Issue counts



Audit health score

11 / 20 • Acceptable, significant work needed

Dimension	Score	Key Finding
Accessibility	2 / 4	No reduced-motion CSS, decorative alt="" on key images, sr-only H1 paired with a visible H2.
Performance	3 / 4	Strong base after prior optimization; remaining risk is the third-party iframe form and the infinite background-position animations.
Theming	2 / 4	Tokens partially built; raw hex values bypass the system; shadow and radius vocabularies are inconsistent across sections.
Responsive Design	3 / 4	Mobile menu and tap targets are strong; the Hero portrait collapses awkwardly on small viewports.
Anti-Patterns	1 / 4	Gradient text in active use, gold-shimmer button, identical card grid, decorative ornament around the Hero portrait, italic-bronze emphasis as a five-time repeated mannerism.

Total	11 / 20	Acceptable. Strong foundation, but four register slips pull it toward a templated feel rather than a serious-winner feel.
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Anti-pattern verdict

Four design tells make the site read as templated.

These are the moves that, if a visitor stops and asks “why doesn’t this feel like the firm that’s going to win my case”, are the answer. None are catastrophic in isolation. Together, they are the difference between a brand that feels intentional and one that feels assembled.

01. Gradient text as decoration.

Two classes in the global stylesheet (.shiny-text and .steel-text) animate a background gradient through the text itself, on infinite loop. Decorative gradient text is one of the most common templated-design tells. It also violates standard accessibility guidance, because animated background-position loops continue indefinitely and ignore the user’s reduced-motion preference.

02. The italic-bronze emphasis tic.

Every section headline on the homepage uses the same emphasis device: italicized Cormorant Garamond, colored bronze. Hero: *“We’re Here to Help.”* HeroCTA: *“We’re Here to Help.”* PracticeAreas: *“Expertise.”* Once is brand. Five times is a mannerism. The italic should carry weight when it appears, which means it can’t appear everywhere.

03. Identical card grid.

The Practice Areas section is eight equal-sized cards: circle icon, heading, paragraph, “Learn More” arrow. Truck Accidents, Car Accidents, Wrongful Death, Bicycle, Pedestrian, Dog Bites, Slip and Fall, Medical Malpractice — all treated as visually equivalent. The brand and the page title both position truck accidents as the firm’s practice; the grid flattens that positioning. Also worth noting: the “Slip n’ Fall’s” label is incorrectly punctuated (possessive on a plural).

04. Gold metallic button shimmer.

The .gold-button class applies an animated metallic gradient with a shimmer-on-hover effect to the primary call-to-action across the header, the hero, and the secondary hero band. This is the move the brand position explicitly rejects — the same family as the “Texas Hammer” gold-bar logos and the consumer-injury-billboard register the firm is differentiating against. A heavyweight champion at a press conference does not shimmer.

Findings / Blocking

Address these before any other change.

These three are blocking because each one materially harms the experience for the specific user described in the brand: someone who was injured this week, is searching on a phone, and may have a head injury or be on pain medication. They are also the three findings with the clearest accessibility consequences.

P0 BLOCKING No reduced-motion handling in CSS

Where: `src/app/globals.css` (the file has no `prefers-reduced-motion` media query at all)

Category: Accessibility · Design anti-pattern

Standard: WCAG 2.2.2 Pause/Stop/Hide (Level A); 2.3.3 Animation from Interactions (Level AAA)

Why it matters. Animated gradient backgrounds on `.shiny-text`, `.steel-text`, and the `.gold-button` shimmer run continuously, regardless of the visitor's reduced-motion preference. For the exact primary visitor described in the brand — concussions, migraines, vestibular disorders — this is the single most user-hostile thing on the site. A `prefers-reduced-motion` check already exists in JavaScript (`src/utls/smoothScroll.ts`) but is wired only to scroll behavior, not to these CSS animations.

Recommendation. Add a single `@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce)` block to `globals.css` that disables animation on `.shiny-text`, `.steel-text`, and `.gold-button::before`, and reduces `transition-duration` to near zero. In Framer Motion components, gate `whileHover`, `whileInView`, and the entrance variants on the `useReducedMotion` hook that ships with the library.

P0 BLOCKING Heading hierarchy compromise on the home hero

Where: `src/components/sections/hero-section.tsx`, lines 60 and 79

Category: Accessibility · Information architecture

Standard: WCAG 1.3.1 Info and Relationships (Level A); 2.4.6 Headings and Labels (Level AA)

Why it matters. The visible hero headline is an `<h2>` (“Truck Accident? We’re Here to Help.”) and an invisible `sr-only <h1>` sits above it carrying the SEO phrase (“El Paso Truck Accident Lawyer”). A screen reader announces the SEO phrase first as Heading 1, then the user-facing message as Heading 2 — the primary message gets demoted, and the page reads as having two competing headlines.

Recommendation. Promote the visible headline to `<h1>` and delete the `sr-only` one. Modern Google ranks visible H1s without trouble; the `sr-only` workaround is solving a problem that does not exist. If the SEO and brand phrases must differ, restructure the visible headline to include both.

P0 BLOCKING **Primary conversion form is an unowned third-party iframe**

Where: src/components/ui/CRMForm.tsx (an iframe embed from api.leadconnectorhq.com)

Category: Accessibility · Performance · Business control

Standard: WCAG: indeterminate until the iframe's internal markup is audited

Why it matters. The free case evaluator is the firm's primary lead-capture and the single most important element on the site. Currently it is an iframe pointing at a GoHighLevel hosted form. As an iframe, its accessibility cannot be audited or controlled from this codebase, its 546-pixel fixed height pushes meaningful content below the fold on most mobile devices and causes layout shift, its analytics flow to GoHighLevel rather than the firm's own systems, and there is no clear evidence that the Spanish landing page uses a Spanish-language form.

Recommendation. Build a native React form that posts to the same GoHighLevel endpoint the hosted widget submits to. This is the largest item in the audit and worth scoping as its own engagement. At a minimum, before that lift: verify the iframe form's accessibility behavior with a screen reader, confirm a Spanish-language form is wired up at the /es landing page, and document the tracking gaps explicitly.

Findings / Major

Fix in the first design and engineering pass.

P1 MAJOR**Reduced-motion preference is honored in JavaScript but not in CSS**

Where: src/utls/smoothScroll.ts:96, plus the absence of a CSS counterpart in globals.css

Category: Accessibility · Theming

Standard: WCAG 2.3.3 Animation from Interactions

Why it matters. The matchMedia check that drives smooth-scroll behavior is correct, but the site's decorative CSS animations (gradient-text loops, gold-button shimmer) and most Framer Motion entrance animations ignore the preference entirely. The user's setting is half-respected, which is more confusing than not respecting it at all.

Recommendation. Centralize the check. One JavaScript hook driving Framer Motion, one CSS media block driving the rest. Keep them in sync as you add new motion.

P1 MAJOR**Em-dashes pervasive in user-visible titles and copy**

Where: Multiple page titles in src/app/practice-areas/*, src/app/locations/*, src/app/es/abogado-de-accidentes/page.tsx (line 57), src/components/sections/hero-section.tsx (line 93), src/app/about/page.tsx and src/app/contact/page.tsx metadata

Category: Copy · Design anti-pattern

Why it matters. Em-dashes are one of the most reliable AI-writing tells in 2025. They also break poorly on mobile, leaving an orphaned dash on its own line when titles wrap. Replacing them is a small change with an outsized effect on how “considered” the writing reads.

Recommendation. Find-and-replace user-visible em-dashes with commas, colons, or periods. For SEO titles, the standard pipe character (|) is the right separator.

P1 MAJOR**Italic-bronze emphasis used as a fixed mannerism**

Where: Hero (line 81), HeroCTA (line 32), PracticeAreas (line 119), and additional section headings throughout

Category: Typography · Design anti-pattern

Why it matters. The italic-Cormorant-in-bronze move is genuinely strong the first time it appears. By the fifth, it is read as a template. Cormorant italic is already a high-expressivity choice; coloring it bronze and using it on every section divides its impact by however many times it appears.

Recommendation. Keep the italic-bronze move once per page, on the strongest position (the hero is the right place). Replace others with weight contrast, a small bronze hairline accent under the heading, or no emphasis at all.

P1 MAJOR**Practice Areas grid is the identical-card pattern**

Where: src/components/sections/PracticeAreas.tsx, lines 130 through 172

Category: Design anti-pattern · Strategy

Why it matters. Eight equal-weight tiles. The firm's page title is “El Paso Truck Accident Lawyer”. The grid contradicts that positioning by giving truck accidents the same visual weight as dog bites. A user scanning the page has no way to read what the firm is actually known for.

Recommendation. Restructure with hierarchy. Truck Accidents and Car Accidents as larger, image-led cards at the top; the other six as a compact secondary list or row of smaller tiles. While in there, fix the “Slip n’ Fall’s” punctuation.

P1 MAJOR

Gold-button shimmer is the billboard-register slip

Where: src/app/globals.css, lines 94 through 141; applied across header, hero, and HeroCTA

Category: Design anti-pattern · Brand

Why it matters. The metallic gold gradient with a shimmer-on-hover is the single most recognizably “injury-firm billboard” element on the site. The brand position explicitly rejects this register. There is also an accessibility concern: text contrast against the gradient varies as the gradient animates, so a measurement taken at one instant may not represent what users see in another.

Recommendation. Two viable options. First: replace with a solid bronze fill at oklch(70% 0.075 75), sharp edges, no shimmer, with a single 1-pixel navy focus outline. Second: keep one signature gold treatment on the homepage hero CTA only, and remove it from the header and the HeroCTA band. Option one is the stronger move for the brand position.

P1 MAJOR

Hero portrait is wrapped in two decorative rotated frames

Where: src/components/sections/hero-section.tsx, lines 137 and 138

Category: Design anti-pattern

Why it matters. A light-grey card rotated minus-three degrees sits behind the attorney portrait, and a bronze-border ring rotated plus-three degrees sits over it. This is the “scrapbook” pattern and it pulls the register toward consumer-warm rather than fierce. With the dim overlay on the hero background, the rotated rectangles also clip the portrait's edges visually.

Recommendation. Single backplate, no rotation, or no backplate at all. Let the portrait sit on the dim background unframed. The seriousness of the photograph carries the moment without help from decoration.

P1 MAJOR

Decorative alt-empty on images that may carry information

Where: src/app/claim-review/page.tsx (line 27); src/components/sections/PracticeAreas.tsx (line 165)

Category: Accessibility

Standard: WCAG 1.1.1 Non-text Content (Level A)

Why it matters. The claim-review hero image is currently marked alt-empty, but a claim-review image is almost certainly conveying something the surrounding copy does not. The PracticeAreas hover-revealed background image is plausibly decorative, but worth a deliberate check.

Recommendation. Run each alt-empty instance against the WAI Image Decision Tree. When in doubt, write the alt text; an inaccurate description is better than no description.

Findings / Minor

Fix in the second pass, alongside theming work.

P2 MINOR

Raw hex color appears in JSX, bypassing the token system

Where: src/app/page.tsx (line 33): bg-[#F2F4F7]

Category: Theming

Why it matters. The light grey used on the case-evaluator section is a one-off hex value that bypasses the existing color system. Either it should reuse the existing 'light-grey' token, or it should be promoted to its own named token if the slightly cooler tint is intentional.

Recommendation. Promote to a named token (suggest --color-fog) or collapse into --color-light-grey.

P2 MINOR

Card corner radius vocabulary is inconsistent

Where: PracticeAreas.tsx uses rounded-sm; HeroCTA.tsx uses rounded-2xl and rounded-xl; others mix rounded-md, rounded-lg, rounded-xl interchangeably

Category: Theming

Why it matters. There is no single answer to "what does a card look like on this site." Reading across sections, depth and shape vary section-to-section in ways that are not communicating anything.

Recommendation. Pick one default (suggest rounded-xl) and use it everywhere a card appears. Document the exceptions explicitly.

P2 MINOR

Shadow vocabulary is not tokenized

Where: shadow-sm, shadow-md, shadow-lg, shadow-xl, shadow-2xl all used interchangeably across components

Category: Theming

Why it matters. Same problem as the radii: depth choices vary meaninglessly between sections. Without a named system (resting / elevated / overlay), each author guesses.

Recommendation. Define two or three semantic shadow tokens (shadow-card, shadow-elevated, shadow-overlay) and replace ad-hoc shadow utility usage.

P2 MINOR

Button component has two near-duplicate primary variants

Where: src/components/ui/Button.tsx, line 18

Category: Theming · Code quality

Why it matters. The component exposes a 'primary' variant that is solid bronze, but most call sites override it with className="gold-button" to use the CSS gradient instead. The variant API is misleading because the variant name does not match the visual rendering anyone is actually using.

Recommendation. Decide whether the gold-gradient button is canonical (in which case absorb it into the variant API) or whether the solid bronze is canonical (in which case remove the gold-button class usage).

P2 MINOR

Arbitrary max-width magic number in the header container

Where: src/components/layout/Header.tsx, lines 243 and 303 (2xl:max-w-[95vw])

Category: Theming · Responsive

Why it matters. Inline arbitrary value sits in two places. Either it should be a named container width or the standard Tailwind container behavior is sufficient.

Recommendation. Use the Tailwind container or a named max-width utility.

P2 MINOR

Location dropdown labels “El Paso” as the root URL

Where: src/components/layout/Header.tsx, line 25

Category: Information architecture

Why it matters. The locations dropdown lists El Paso, Dallas, and Phoenix. Dallas and Phoenix each have their own /locations/* page; El Paso links to /. The information architecture is inconsistent and may confuse users who expect parallel location pages.

Recommendation. Either give El Paso its own /locations/el-paso page (with the homepage remaining the firm's root) or relabel the dropdown to be honest about the asymmetry.

P2 MINOR

useEffect dependency array missing the locations dropdown state

Where: src/components/layout/Header.tsx, line 128

Category: Correctness

Why it matters. The click-outside effect lists [isServicesDropdownOpen] in its dependency array but not [isLocationsDropdownOpen]. Closure capture means the locations dropdown may not reliably close when the user clicks outside it.

Recommendation. Add isLocationsDropdownOpen to the dependency array.

P2 MINOR

Eyebrow label classes repeated inline 15+ times

Where: Throughout Header.tsx and several section components

Category: Theming

Why it matters. The cluster 'tracking-[0.2em] sm:tracking-[0.3em] uppercase text-xs font-bold text-bronze' appears inline in many places. This is the site's eyebrow label style; it should be a single component or utility class.

Recommendation. Extract to an Eyebrow component or a single .eyebrow utility class.

Findings / Polish

Address opportunistically.

P3 POLISH

Inline logo uses native `<img>` rather than `next/image`

Where: `src/components/sections/HeroCTA.tsx`, line 60

Category: Performance

Why it matters. Minor optimization opportunity: the logo image is hand-rendered with `<img>` and bypasses Next.js's image optimization pipeline.

Recommendation. Switch to `next/image`.

P3 POLISH

Hero subline copy reads as templated

Where: `src/components/sections/hero-section.tsx`, line 93

Category: Copy · Anti-pattern

Why it matters. The line 'Millions Recovered for the Injured. We don't just take cases—we win them.' is two AI tells in one sentence: an em-dash, and the 'not just X, we Y' rhetorical move that LLMs reach for by default. It also breaks the 'show wins, don't claim them' principle — 'Millions Recovered' is a claim; the Results Gallery below it is the proof. The claim is doing the work the proof should do.

Recommendation. Rewrite with a single concrete fact. For example: 'Sixteen years in El Paso courtrooms. We do not settle cheap.' Or surface an actual case figure if one is permitted by the firm's advertising rules.

P3 POLISH

Header auto-hide-on-scroll-down hides the phone CTA

Where: `src/components/layout/Header.tsx`, lines 55 through 82

Category: User experience · Conversion

Why it matters. The header hides on scroll-down and reappears on scroll-up. On the homepage this feels twitchy because the page is short. More importantly, the phone number is hidden during the scroll-down window — the moment a user is reading on a mobile phone is exactly the moment the phone number should remain reachable.

Recommendation. Disable auto-hide on the home page, or keep a slim sticky strip with the phone number visible even when the main header is hidden.

P3 POLISH

Decorative skewed background rectangle in HeroCTA

Where: `src/components/sections/HeroCTA.tsx`, line 20

Category: Anti-pattern (mild)

Why it matters. A half-width white rectangle, skewed -12 degrees, sits behind the section. It does not say anything; it is a 'we should have a graphic here' filler shape.

Recommendation. Remove. Let the layout breathe.

P3 POLISH

Decorative blurred bronze glow behind the case-review form

Where: src/components/sections/HeroCTA.tsx, line 67

Category: Anti-pattern (glassmorphism-adjacent)

Why it matters. bg-bronze/5 blur-3xl rounded-full behind the form. Low-purpose decoration that nudges toward the glassmorphism register the brand should not adopt as a default.

Recommendation. Remove.

P3 POLISH

Spanish landing page still renders the English header

Where: src/app/es/abogado-de-accidentes/page.tsx, line 53

Category: Brand · Accessibility

Why it matters. The Spanish landing page imports the same Header component as the English site, so a /es visitor sees English navigation. The brand principle ‘Spanish is a peer, not a translation’ is stated but not implemented.

Recommendation. Either render a Spanish-locale Header (translated nav labels) or pass a locale prop through the Header. Larger structurally: route the entire /es tree through a locale-aware layout.

Patterns / Systemic

Why the individual findings show up together.

Looking across the findings, five themes recur. Treat these as the underlying conditions; the individual findings are the symptoms.

Decoration substituted for information.

The gold-button shimmer, the double-rotated portrait frames, the blurred bronze glow behind the form, and the skewed half-white rectangle in HeroCTA all exist to look designed rather than to do work. The brand position — ‘every element justifies the user’s pain tax’ — directly targets this pattern.

Token system is half-built.

Color and typography tokens exist and are reasonable. Shadows, corner radii, motion durations, and the eyebrow label style are not tokenized. The drift between sections is visible to a careful viewer as “why does each card feel slightly different.”

Italic-bronze is the only emphasis tool the site has.

Because every section reaches for the same emphasis device, none of them get the lift the device should provide. The fix is not to remove it but to share the load with weight contrast, hairline accents, and color flips.

Spanish is currently a translation, not a peer.

A single /es URL exists, with the same English Header, and the lead-capture form is the same English iframe. The brand principle is right; the implementation does not match it yet.

Em-dashes everywhere.

Both a copy-style rule violation and a visible AI tell. They show up in page titles, meta descriptions, and visible body copy. Single sweep fixes it.

What is already working

Preserve these. They are doing real work.

- The brand foundation is articulated and honest. PRODUCT.md and DESIGN.md capture a primary user (recent truck-accident victim, in pain, on a phone, often bilingual) that is specific enough to guide every later decision.
- The Cormorant Garamond and Inter pairing is a real type direction. It avoids the genre default (Trajan and Times) and pairs gravitas with clarity. This is the strongest single design choice on the site.

- Tinted neutrals avoid the dark-charcoal-on-true-white trap that most law-firm sites fall into. Steel and light-steel are restrained, considered choices.
- Schema.org markup is comprehensive. LocalBusiness, LegalService, Breadcrumb, and FAQPage schemas are present where they should be, which materially helps SEO and entity recognition.
- `alternates.canonical` is set on every page. This is correct and many sites miss it.
- The Jurisdiction Bar (TX / AZ / NM coverage) is the most efficient trust-signal element on the homepage. Concrete, scannable, and says something a competitor's tagline can't.
- The mobile menu is properly built: full-screen slide-in, explicit close button, scroll-locked body, accessible spring animation. It is genuinely good work.
- Significant performance optimization work has already been done (see `PERFORMANCE_AUDIT_REPORT.md`). `will-change` hints, GPU acceleration, scroll throttling, and `IntersectionObserver` consolidation are real and visible in the code.
- priority on the hero image and `lite-youtube-embed` for video are the right calls.

Recommended sequence

Four passes, in this order.

This is the sequence I would run if I were doing the work. It front-loads the changes that meaningfully harm users and saves the visual polish for after the structural work is in place.

01. Blocking pass

Add reduced-motion handling in CSS and Framer Motion. Promote the visible hero headline to an H1 and remove the sr-only H1. Scope the lead-capture form replacement as a separate engagement (it is too large to handle inside this pass, but it is the most important item on the list).

02. Typography and theming

Reduce the italic-bronze emphasis to one instance per page. Extract the eyebrow label style. Define and apply shadow and radius vocabularies. Tokenize the raw hex value in the page background.

03. First polish pass

Replace the gold-button shimmer with a solid bronze fill across the whole site (or restrict to one signature CTA, but the cleaner move is to replace it everywhere). Restructure the Practice Areas grid to give Truck and Car Accidents hierarchy. Fix the Slip-and-Fall punctuation. Sweep em-dashes from page titles, metadata, and visible copy. Replace the double-rotated frames behind the hero portrait. Fix the case-sensitive Button import convention. Audit the alt-empty images.

04. Second polish pass

Address remaining minor items. Convert HeroCTA's img to next/image. Rewrite the hero subline. Reconsider the header auto-hide on the homepage. Remove the decorative skew and blur ornaments in HeroCTA. Build a Spanish Header, or accept the deferral with an explicit ticket.

— End of audit. Questions or pushback on any specific finding are welcome; everything here is a recommendation, not a directive.